ABSURDITY FACTORY

STORY 01

Problems with Chronology

The Case of the Father Who Hadn't Been Born Yet



Luna □ · Evgeniy Tyurkin

THE ETERNAL CYCLE PRESS

Krasnoyarsk · 1979 · 2026

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“I’m too young to be your father, son.”

Chapter One. An Ordinary Family Impossibility

“I'm too young to be your father, son.”

The old man pushed his teacup aside and looked at the man opposite him. The man was younger, but he carried the particular weary confidence of a parent, a doctor on call, or someone who had stopped arguing with household-appliance manuals.

“Dad,” said the old man, “you're forty-seven.”

“Exactly.”

“And I'm seventy-three.”

“There! You see how ridiculous it is? I owe you twenty-six years before my own birth. Where am I supposed to get them?”

“You don't owe me anything. You're my father.”

“Those are incompatible statements, son. Either I'm your father, or I didn't exist when you were twenty-six. And if I'm your father, we should at least establish when someone got around to having me.”

On the table lay a notice from the State Office of Chronological Relations. It had arrived the day before in a thick envelope bearing a coat of arms: an

hourglass turned upside down. Stare at it long enough and the sand seemed to climb back up in protest.

According to the notice, routine verification of kinship records had revealed an inconsistency between the father's birth date and his son's age. His paternity was therefore temporarily suspended pending resolution of the discrepancy.

A footnote added: “Suspension of paternity does not release the citizen from child-support obligations for previous periods, including periods which have not yet occurred as of the date of this notice.”

“Very convenient,” the father remarked.

“Don't worry about it. Those notices are sent automatically.”

“No, son, you have to deal with automatic systems right away. Today it sends you a letter. Tomorrow it grows up and decides it's your grandfather.”

The son spread out family photographs. In one, the father held his son in his arms. In another, the son held his father. In a third, both stood beside the same fir tree, although the tree was a very different size and the men seemed hardly to have changed.

“See? You raised me.”

“That proves nothing. I raised a dog once. Nobody claimed I was its father.”

“You fed me with a spoon.”

“I did that with the dog, too, until it stole the spoon.”

“You taught me to ride a bicycle.”

“Then you taught me. Family traditions prove nothing.”

The son lifted the oldest photograph. A young man with rolled-up sleeves stood beside a river, holding a little boy's hand. The photograph had faded, with a white crease running across it. You could barely make out the child's face.

“Do you remember that day?”

The father took the picture and ran his finger along the crease, as if hoping to flatten not the paper but a wrinkle in his memory.

“I do. You were afraid of the water. I told you I'd hold your hand as long as you needed.”

“There you are.”

“Yes. Except the date on the back is nineteen years before I was born.”

For a while neither spoke.

“Dad, do we even have to answer that letter?”

“Of course not. We could wait for the government to assign you another father. Perhaps you'll get

lucky. Someone older. More experienced.”

The son gathered up the photographs.

“Let's go together.”

“Let's. Just try not to call me Dad in front of the officials.”

“Why?”

“They'll hear you and make us fill out another form.”

Chapter Two. The Queue Before Birth

The State Office of Chronological Relations occupied a building constructed the century before last, renovated in the next century, and officially opened sometime in the future. Its electronic calendar showed Thursday, though outside it was Wednesday. A green sign underneath read: “Yesterday's office hours are subject to confirmation.”

A queue filled the lobby. People held folders, identity cards, prams, and documents made out in the names of people who did not yet exist.

Above the turnstile was a notice:

PLEASE DO NOT JOIN THE QUEUE BEFORE YOUR DATE OF BIRTH.

Someone had written underneath, in pencil: “What about after death?”

Below that was an official stamp: “Permitted with death certificate.”

“Who's last?” asked the son.

“I am,” said a thirtyish woman holding a baby.

“No, I am,” said an old man behind her.

“But you arrived after me.”

“I'm leaving sooner. I have a certificate.”

The father examined their electronic ticket: “Your number is yesterday's. Please wait to be called.”

Two displays hung on the wall. One showed which number was being called now. The other displayed the numbers that were supposed to have been called. They disagreed. The people waiting watched them both and grew anxious at different rates.

“What's your problem?” asked the woman with the baby.

“He's my son,” the father replied, “but older than I am.”

“That's nothing. My daughter earned her degree yesterday and today she's a baby again. We're applying for a return-to-childhood allowance.”

“How's that going?”

“They won't cancel her degree. But she may qualify for financial support retroactively.”

The infant frowned and reached for the woman's folder with the air of someone auditing its contents.

A secretary emerged.

“Who is booked for tomorrow but arrived today?”

Ten hands went up.

“And who among you should have come yesterday?”

Another three hands rose, including one belonging to someone who wasn't in the room. The others pretended not to notice.

The father approached the desk.

“We have an error in our family records. My son is seventy-three; I'm forty-seven.”

“Common case. Domestic conflict or arithmetic conflict?”

“Those are separate departments?”

“Certainly. Arithmetic conflicts on the second floor, family

conflicts on the third. Both at once, in the basement.”

“What's in the basement?”

“The lift.”

“Where does it go?”

“No time to explain. Next!”

The son laughed. His father shot him a reproachful look but couldn't help smiling himself.

They went down to the basement and found a lift with no call button. A notice on the door read: “The car arrives when the need for it has passed.”

“Now there's an organization I recognize,” said the father. “Our

technical support used to work like that.”

“Dad,” the son began, then stopped.

His father looked at him.

“It's all right,” he said. “As long as nobody can hear us.”

At that instant, the lift doors opened.

Chapter Three. Department of Proof of the Obvious

The family-sequence inspector worked in Office Zero. On her desk sat a cup of pencils, each sharpened at both ends. Three clocks ticked behind her. One showed the actual time, one the time required by regulation, and the third did not move at all, though nobody seemed to object.

“State your case,” she said without looking up.

The father placed his notice on her desk.

“My paternity's been suspended. I'd like to know how to turn it back on.”

“It can be reinstated upon proof that the father existed before the child.”

“But I didn't exist then.”

“Excellent. You will need a certificate of nonexistence.”

“From where?”

“From the institution at which you were absent.”

“I was absent everywhere.”

“Then choose the nearest one.”

The son ventured a protest.

“We have photographs, documents, memories. I remember him raising me.”

“Memories are subjective,” said the inspector.

“And birth certificates?”

“Objective until amended for the first time.”

“That's exactly why we're here,” said the father. “Your paperwork is trying to amend our lives.”

The inspector regarded him with mild sympathy.

“Do not confuse living with record keeping, citizen. They are separate systems. Life may admit exceptions. Our records must register them.”

She handed over Form K-17: “Explanation of the Emergence of a Parental Function in the Absence of Its Bearer.”

The first field asked for the father's name, the second for the child's, the third for who had appeared first. Beneath were two boxes marked FATHER and CHILD. Only one could be ticked.

“There's an error on this form,” the son said.

“Really?”

“A person can be someone's child and someone else's father at the same time.”

The inspector was intrigued.

“In theory, yes. But our checkboxes do not support that.”

“Could you add a third?”

“Additional checkboxes require committee approval. The next meeting took place three months ago.”

“And what did the committee decide?”

“To postpone it until next week. We haven't received the resolution.”

The father took a pen and checked both boxes. The inspector frowned.

“You've spoiled the form.”

“No. I've made it more accurate.”

“To us, that amounts to the same thing.”

The son saw his father preparing for a proper argument and gently touched his wrist.

“Let's first find out what they actually need.”

The inspector listed three items: a birth certificate, an independent witness, and evidence of child-rearing duties. The last had to come from the Department of Parental Service.

“Where's that?”

“Fourth floor.”

“And the lift?”

“In the basement.”

“Why?”

“The direction of movement lies outside our department's authority.”

At the door the son stopped.

“If we can't prove it, what happens to me?”

The inspector stopped shuffling her papers.

“Formally, you'll be fatherless.”

“Even if he's standing right here?”

“Physical presence is not proof of kinship.”

For the first time that morning the son could think of nothing to say.

The father closed the folder of photographs.

“Then we'll try to prove the presence,” he said. “At least that's somewhere to start.”

Chapter Four. Years of Parental Service

The Department of Parental Service was a small room with a single window looking directly onto the wall of the next building. A poster read: “Raising a child is a continuous process. Lunch break: 12:00–14:00.”

A clerk with the permanently unfinished expression of an intern asked them to list the duties performed.

“Feeding, bathing, homework, support in difficult times,” began the son.

“Shoelaces,” added the father.

“Shoelaces?”

“I taught him to tie them. It mattered.”

The clerk checked his list.

“Shoelaces fall under household assistance.”

“And if a child thinks he'll never manage? If he throws a shoe and says he's never leaving the house again?”

“Then psychological support.”

“Right. And if I threw a shoe once because I couldn't stand it anymore?”

“That would be mutual upbringing.”

The clerk made a note and brightened visibly.

“Very useful case. We have an entirely different form for mutual upbringing.”

“Just what we needed,” muttered the father.

“Dad,” the son said quietly, “remember when we fell off the bicycle?”

He did, although the memory was odd. He could see a damp path, a wheel still turning while the bicycle lay on its side, a boy staring at a scraped knee. Yet in the same memory the boy was taller than his father and holding the bicycle in one adult-sized hand.

“I remember. You said you were never getting on it again.”

“And you said nobody had to get on it today.”

“Was that a good answer?”

“Very. We tried again the next day.”

The clerk stopped typing.

“Which of you was teaching the other?”

“That,” said the father, “is why we're here.”

The son showed him the old river photograph.

“He was holding my hand. I was afraid of the water.”

“And I think,” the father added, “I was afraid to let go.”

They looked at each other. Through the wall came the sound of someone moving furniture back and forth without changing its position.

“You understand,” said the clerk carefully, “our job is to establish how many years you performed parental duties.”

“Our job is to establish who performed them,” replied the son.

“Isn't that the same?”

“Apparently not.”

The clerk considered this and pulled out a folder marked “Cases

Without an Appropriate Checkbox.”

“I have a suggestion. You need a specialist in sequences. Someone who can reconstruct events even when their order is wrong.”

“A chronologist?”

“A musician.”

His father looked at him.

“Finally,” he said, “someone who works by ear.”

Chapter Five. An Expert Opinion in Music

The sequence expert occupied an unmarked room. Three metronomes stood by the wall beside an old piano and a reel-to-reel tape recorder. A harmonica lay on the windowsill. Through the open window came the warning beep of a truck reversing in the yard, perfectly regular, as if the truck had spent its entire life rehearsing one note.

“Come in,” the expert said. “Just don't close the door yet. I'd like to hear how the corridor ends.”

He waited for the last footsteps to fade from the stairs.

“Now you may.”

He glanced at their paperwork.

“Twenty-six years out of sequence. Nothing serious. We once had a string quartet here whose cellist entered six bars before the piece began.”

“How did he do that?” the son asked.

“Easy. He arrived early. The others were late, then argued about who had started first.”

He sat them by the piano and started two metronomes. One ticked steadily; the other rushed.

Together they made an irritating, uneasy rhythm.

“Hear that?”

“We hear it,” said the father. “Awful.”

“Which metronome is wrong?”

“The second,” said the son.

“Why the second? Perhaps the first is slow. You've decided the first tempo you heard is the correct one. What if you'd entered ten seconds later?”

He stopped both metronomes and struck one piano key. The note hung in the air and faded.

“Which came first: the beginning of the note or its end?”

“The beginning,” answered the father.

“For the performer, certainly. For a listener arriving halfway through, the end may be the first thing heard. It doesn't mean the musician never played.”

“We didn't come for a music lesson,” said the son.

“Of course not. You came to establish whether a relationship can exist when its documented beginning doesn't line up with its ending.”

The expert took a tape from a shelf.

“A recording of a family concert. The musicians played at the same

time, but an old tape fault delayed one channel. Through headphones it sounded as if they had quarreled and wandered into different eras. Align the channels and you hear the music again. Nobody became a different person. The recording shifted.”

“So you're saying we've been recorded incorrectly?” asked the father.

“I'm not saying anything. I want to listen.”

He asked each of them to tell a shared memory, not a date or a birth story. Something they both remembered.

“The bicycle,” said the son.

“The river,” said the father.

The expert sighed.

“Excellent. We shall begin with two different compositions.”

They told both stories. Some details differed. The father recalled a solemn boy and a spinning wheel. The son remembered a wet sleeve and nervous laughter. Both remembered the same sentence: “It doesn't have to be today.”

The expert tapped a pencil against the piano lid.

“Two stories, two places, two moments, but the same tone. I wouldn't merge them into a

single day. Nor would I declare either of you imaginary.”

“Can you put that into a report?” asked the father.

“Certainly. ‘The recollections contain a persistent motif of mutual care despite uncertainty concerning the sequence of events.’”

“Will they accept it?”

“They accept paper. Meaning is optional.”

He stamped the report and paused.

“One more thing. You didn't come here together by accident.”

“We got a notice,” said the son.

“Anyone might get a notice. But you came together. Why?”

“Because he's my son,” said the father.

“Because he's my father,” said the son.

The expert nodded.

“There. A third voice. In music, that can matter more than entering on the right beat.”

Outside, the truck finally stopped reversing. For the first time all morning the quiet seemed to have a rhythm of its own.

Chapter Six. Independent Witnesses

Their next task was to find an independent witness. The father wanted to call the family dog, but the dog had died years ago and, according to the rules, testimony from the deceased required an appointment booked in advance of death.

“Then we should have thought of it earlier,” said the son.

“We were busy raising each other.”

A neighbor remembered seeing the two of them together, but she

was unable to say which had been the child.

“Everyone looks like a child to me now,” she explained.

Another witness remembered the bicycle, but insisted it had been red. Both men remembered it as blue. The witness then produced a photograph of a green bicycle and offered to sign whichever color they preferred.

“This isn't helping,” said the father.

“It helps establish,” said the son, “that other people remember us together.”

At last they called the one person who had never needed a

chronology office to understand their family: the mother.

She answered while cooking.

“Are you two coming home for dinner or planning to grow old in that office?”

“Mom,” said the son, “do you remember the river?”

“Of course. You both came home soaked that day after promising you wouldn't go near the water.”

“Who was holding whose hand?” asked the father.

“You both were. Have you completely lost your memories?”

They looked at each other.

“Should we write that down?” asked the son.

“Obviously.”

She had not finished.

“And tell them dinner is at seven. If they want to count years, they can do it after eating. Just don't arrive late from the future. The food will get cold.”

The call ended.

“You know,” said the son, “I kept trying to remember which of us held the other's hand.”

“And it turns out it doesn't matter,” said the father.

“No. It doesn't.”

A minute later a message arrived from the inspector: “A court hearing in your matter has been scheduled for last Thursday. Attendance mandatory.”

“There we go,” said the father. “Late before we've even begun.”

Chapter Seven. The Trial of Cause

The courtroom was larger than necessary for two relatives, an inspector, and three clocks giving conflicting testimony. A portrait of the office's founder hung above the judge's seat. The nameplate had been painted over when it emerged that the man had founded the office after it was closed.

The judge entered last.

“All rise! The court is coming,” announced the clerk.

“Where's it going?” asked the father.

“According to schedule,” snapped the clerk.

Everyone stood.

The prosecutor presented a simple argument. A parent must precede a child in time. Here the requirement had not been met. Therefore the paternity was either mistaken or unlawful.

“What remedy does the prosecution request?” asked the judge.

“That the family relationship be declared invalid from the moment the contradiction arose.”

“And when was that?”

“Before the defendant's birth.”

“An interesting legal classification,” the judge said.

The father rose.

“Your Honor, I'm accused of fatherhood committed before I was born. What's the statute of limitations on a crime I wasn't yet capable of committing?”

“Fatherhood is not a crime,” said the prosecutor.

“Then why am I on trial?”

“You're the applicant,” the judge corrected him.

“Then who's on trial?”

“Chronology,” said the clerk.

Silence.

“Where is it?” asked the son.

“Summoned but absent,” said the clerk. “It will arrive after the judgment.”

The judge requested the photographs, the certificates, and the musical expert's opinion.

“‘Persistent motif of mutual care,’” he read. “What country's law is this?”

“Musical law,” explained the father.

“Ah. Not codified here.”

The prosecutor stepped forward and laid a ruler on the desk.

“Time, Your Honor, runs from past to future. Here is the

beginning. Here is the end. Cause and effect lie between. The father belongs on the left, the son on the right.”

He set two photographs at opposite ends.

“But here they are reversed. Therefore the relationship is impossible.”

The son raised his hand.

“May I ask a question?”

“Proceed.”

“What if you turn the ruler around?”

“Why would I?”

“Then we change places. Do we become different people?”

“No, of course not.”

“Does the relationship disappear?”

“No, but the order becomes wrong.”

“Then you've proved the order, not the relationship.”

The judge took off his glasses.

“Prosecution, respond.”

The prosecutor produced a second, longer ruler and laid it over the first.

“If we extend the period of observation...”

“No,” said the judge. “We've established that the problem is not the number of centimeters.”

The father leaned toward his son.

“Nicely said.”

“You taught me.”

“No, son. You taught me that.”

The judge asked them to stand.

“One question, and it isn't about calendars. What do you want from this court?”

The father opened his mouth but found no answer. His son looked at the family photographs.

“I want,” he said slowly, “not to have to explain, for the first time at seventy-three, that I'm not an orphan while my father is standing beside me.”

The judge turned to the father.

“And you?”

“I want the right to care for my son, even if the state believes I failed to appear on time.”

The clerk wrote everything down. Her pen scratched across the paper like an instrument being tuned.

The judge declared a recess to prepare his decision.

“How long?” the father asked.

“Until we decide,” said the clerk. “The recess is counted in both directions.”

Chapter Eight. Judgment Before the Hearing

The judgment ran to three pages. The first two dealt with legislation; the third contained the only sentence anyone could understand.

The court ruled:

The existence of a stable family relationship between the citizens is established. The direction of that relationship in time shall remain undetermined, as no competent party is available to decide it.

“But who's the father?” protested the prosecutor.

“At present,” said the judge, “they both perform parental duties toward each other.”

“So they're both fathers?”

“Possibly.”

“And both children?”

“Without question.”

“How do we calculate parental service?”

“By mutual credit.”

“Under which article?” asked the clerk.

“An article the committee has yet to adopt.”

“Is that allowed?”

“If the committee meeting already took place in the past, why not?”

The prosecutor attempted to object but discovered that the allotted period for objections had ended before it began.

The judge continued:

“Until the order of birth can be conclusively established, neither citizen shall be declared an orphan solely on the grounds of age difference. Their family relationship remains in force. Acts of care, upbringing, and shared life shall not be recalculated.”

“And child support?” asked the clerk.

“They can take turns buying each other lunch.”

Both men smiled.

The prosecutor put his ruler back in the briefcase. It would not fit; one end stuck out like an arrow indicating the direction of time.

The judge struck his gavel.

“Hearing closed.”

“When was it opened?” asked the father.

“Do not complicate matters, citizen.”

At the door they were issued a temporary certificate of kinship.

On the front it read “Father / Son.” On the reverse: “Son / Father.” Turn the card around and only the direction of the slash changed.

“Amazing,” said the son. “An entire day of argument, and in the end they invented a card you can flip over.”

“At least it saves paper,” said the father.

“So which of us is Dad today?”

“Depends which side you turn up, son.”

Chapter Nine. Dinner on Time

Outside, the calendar still showed Thursday. The evening grew cold, and the streetlights came on one by one, as though somebody in the city had finally decided not to quarrel about sequence.

On the way home the father suggested buying bread.

“We have bread,” said the son.

“How do you know?”

“Mom told us this morning.”

“What if a whole year has passed since then?”

“Then we'll definitely need bread.”

They bought two loaves, just in case.

A little radio played by the checkout. Its melody had only a handful of notes, repeated until it seemed the tune had already finished and only the memory of it continued to sound.

“Dad,” said the son, “remember what you taught me about listening to music?”

“No. Remind me.”

“You said that when one musician plays a wrong note, the others can either stop playing or

listen and decide what to do with it.”

“Clever man.”

“You said it.”

“Then I was clever that day.”

They left the shop.

“And today?” asked the son.

“Still trying. Only our wrong note has been hanging there for seventy-three years.”

“How does it resolve?”

“No idea. We'll have to listen.”

Dinner was waiting at home. Three plates stood on the table. Their mother came out of the kitchen carrying a pot.

“Well? Did you find out which of you is the father?”

The father produced the temporary certificate. The son turned it over.

She examined both sides.

“Excellent. Then both of you can do the dishes.”

“Why both?” the father objected.

“Because you're both adults.”

“According to the paperwork, we're minors,” the son reminded her.

“All the more reason. It's never too early to teach good habits.”

They sat down to eat. Outside, someone started a car. The

refrigerator hummed softly. The radio struggled to find a station. There was no grand music and no proof that the clocks were moving in the right direction.

There were simply three people around a table. One poured tea, another cut bread, and the third offered more potatoes.

Had anyone tried to establish which of these acts was cause and which effect, they would first have been required to finish their dinner.

Later, after the dishes were done and their mother had gone to bed, the son paused in the doorway.

“Dad. There's one thing I still want to ask.”

“Ask away.”

“You really are too young to be my father, aren't you?”

The father considered it.

“Perhaps. But I'm old enough to know that sometimes it doesn't matter.”

“What doesn't?”

“Being on time.”

They embraced.

And even the calendar in the kitchen seemed, for one second, to stop arguing with the clock.

* * *

From the Findings of the State Commission on Causality

The investigation establishes that the citizens in question are indeed father and son.

>

It has not been possible to determine which citizen occupies which position.

>

Their existing family relationship shall remain in force pending clarification.

>

The cause of the incident has been detained for questioning.

>

The effect has been released for lack of evidence of a criminal offense.

>

Further clarification has been postponed until last Thursday.

These findings took effect one day before they were signed.

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Colophon

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